

Magawa the Hero Rat Immortalized in Stone

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When you think of rats, "hero" is probably not the first word that comes to mind. But Magawa was no ordinary rodent. From his birth in 2013 to his passing in 2022, this African giant pouched rat helped save hundreds of lives in Cambodia by sniffing out hidden **landmines**. On April 3, 2026, Magawa was honored with a seven-foot (2.1 m) stone statue in the city of Siem Reap. The unveiling was timed to coincide with the International Day for Mine Awareness on April 4. Magawa was part of an elite group of giant pouched rats called **HeroRATS**. They are trained by the Belgian non-profit organization **APOPO** to safely detect **explosives** left behind by past wars. These rodents are especially well-suited for this work. Their incredibly sharp sense of smell helps them sniff out **chemical compounds** in **explosives**. Although larger than most rats, they are light enough to walk over buried **landmines** without setting them off. This combination of size and sense makes them extremely efficient. A single rat can search an area the size of a tennis court in just 20 minutes. This task would take a human with a metal detector up to four days. Magawa spent five years working in Cambodia. During his career, the rodent cleared nearly 1.5 million sq. feet (140,000 sq. m) of land. He set a new record by finding more than 100 **landmines**. In 2020, Magawa received a miniature gold medal for his bravery from the UK veterinary charity **PDSA**. He retired in 2021 and passed away peacefully at the age of eight in 2022. **Landmines**, left behind by past wars, remain a danger in Cambodia and several other countries in Southeast Asia. These hidden **explosives** make everyday activities like farming, building homes, or even walking to school dangerous. But thanks to the **HeroRATS**, more than 120,000 **landmines** have been removed so far. Once cleared, these areas can be used again for crops, businesses, and homes. Magawa may be gone, but his legacy and now his statue will inspire generations.

Word Treasure

landmines -- Buried explosive devices designed to explode when stepped on, left over from past wars.

explosives -- Substances that can suddenly release a large amount of energy and cause an explosion.

HeroRATS -- A group of specially trained African giant pouched rats that detect landmines and save lives.

APOPO -- A Belgian non-profit organization that trains rats to detect landmines and tuberculosis.

chemical compounds -- Mixtures of different elements that make up specific substances, such as those found in explosives.

PDSA -- A British veterinary charity that gives awards for animal bravery, like the gold medal Magawa received.

Background you need

The use of rats to detect landmines was pioneered by APOPO, a Belgian non-profit organization founded in the 1990s that trains African giant pouched rats to sniff out explosives.

Landmines became widespread in Cambodia during its civil war in the 1970s and 1980s, when various factions laid millions of mines, many of which still pose a threat today.

Magawa was honored with a statue in Siem Reap, the Cambodian city that serves as the gateway to the famous Angkor Wat temple complex.

The PDSA Gold Medal, awarded to Magawa in 2020, is a prestigious honor from the UK's leading veterinary charity--Magawa was the first rat ever to receive it.

By 2026, HeroRATS have helped clear over 120,000 landmines across several countries, allowing once-dangerous land to be used safely again.

Break it down

LEAD: Contrasting public perception of rats with Magawa's heroism.

+ specific: Introduction of Magawa as an African giant pouched rat.

KEY EVENT: Unveiling of a 7-ft (2.1 m) stone statue in Siem Reap.

+ DATE: April 3, 2026, coinciding with Mine Awareness Day (April 4).

+ SIGNIFICANCE: Honors a life-saving rodent.

EXPLANATION: How rats detect landmines.

+ TRAINING: By APOPO, a Belgian non-profit, as HeroRATS.

+ SENSE: Sharp smell detects chemical compounds in explosives.

+ SAFETY: Light enough not to trigger mines.

EFFICIENCY: A rat clears a tennis-court area in 20 min vs 4 days for a human with a metal detector.

MAGAWA'S ACHIEVEMENTS:

+ 5 years in Cambodia, cleared 1.5 million sq ft (140,000 sq m).

+ Record: Found 100+ landmines.

+ Award: PDSA miniature gold medal in 2020.

CONTEXT: Landmines remain a danger in Cambodia and Southeast Asia.

+ IMPACT: Farming, building, walking to school become dangerous.

+ SOLUTION: HeroRATs have removed 120,000+ mines so far.

LEGACY: Statue will inspire future generations toward mine clearance.

Why it matters

This story shows how innovative animal partnerships can solve deadly problems that still affect children in post-conflict nations--proving that creative thinking can make the world safer for everyone.

Test what you remember

1. What was Magawa trained to detect?

- ☐ (A) Tuberculosis
- ☐ (B) Landmines
- ☐ (C) Both landmines and tuberculosis
- ☐ (D) Metal objects

2. How long did it take Magawa to search an area the size of a tennis court?

- ☐ (A) 4 days
- ☐ (B) 2 hours
- ☐ (C) 20 minutes
- ☐ (D) 1 day

3. What honor did Magawa receive in 2020?

- ☐ (A) A golden statue
- ☐ (B) A miniature gold medal from PDSA
- ☐ (C) A special collar from APOPO
- ☐ (D) A certificate from the UN

4. How many landmines did Magawa find during his career?

- ☐ (A) Exactly 100
- ☐ (B) More than 100
- ☐ (C) Less than 50
- ☐ (D) Around 200

5. Where was Magawa's statue unveiled?

- ☐ (A) Phnom Penh
- ☐ (B) Siem Reap
- ☐ (C) Battambang
- ☐ (D) Angkor Wat

6. Why are African giant pouched rats well-suited for landmine detection?

- ☐ (A) They are very strong and can dig holes
- ☐ (B) They have sharp sense of smell but are light enough not to trigger mines
- ☐ (C) They can fly over minefields
- ☐ (D) They are naturally attracted to the smell of metal

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

1. **Positive:** HeroRATS save lives and return land to communities, showing that rats can be heroes. Magawa's statue cements the respect these animals deserve for their work.
2. **Critical:** Some animal-rights advocates question whether it is ethical to train and deploy animals in dangerous detection work, although APOPO emphasizes the rats' safety and care.
3. **Neutral:** Using rats is a cost-effective alternative to expensive machinery; their speed and accuracy highlight a practical intersection of biology and humanitarian aid.
4. **Forward-looking:** As HeroRATS expand to other landmine-affected countries, this model could be paired with new sensor technology to clear remaining minefields faster.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):